Mahmood Khan, a young parliamentarian from Kandahar, for instance, asserted that India's 'heavy investment' in Afghanistan's reconstruction was highly cherished by Afghans from across the spectrum.[43] Critically, Khan concurred, these projects, big and small, buttressed India's image as a growing economic power that could support Afghanistan in the long run, and whose developmental and democratic model Afghanistan could emulate. Jawed Ludin, Janan Musazai, and Ershad Ahmadi, all senior foreign policy officials in the Afghan government also testified that the SDPs played an important role in impacting lives of the locals in rural Afghanistan.[44] However, there was no accounting for how the SDP funds were actually used once they had been handed over to the local Afghan administration on the ground. For Mohammad Tariq Ismati, Afghanistan's former deputy minister at the Ministry of Rural Rehabilitation and Development (MRRD), keeping track of every project was not possible, and calculating exactly what impact these projects had on the ground was also not possible.[45] Afghan Chief Executive Abdullah Abdullah, a close ally of India, was even more sceptical:

> Perhaps that [SDPs] was to win the hearts and minds of the population given how that was done. I don't know. The focus was mostly in eastern and southern part of Afghanistan. And looking at the situation there and how helpful such assistance was towards stabilising those areas is a big question mark.[46]

While there is no systematic evaluation of the Afghan Taliban's perspectives on Indian developmental projects, the few existing media reports indicate that despite being sceptical of India's political intent behind these projects, they generally welcomed the Indian presence.[47] Bitter that India never invested so heavily in Afghanistan's developmental sector in the 1990s, Taliban spokesperson Zabiullah Mujahid stated in 2010 that all these projects were meant to promote India's interests in Afghanistan. 'If India were so fond of the Afghan people, why did it not undertake development projects under Taliban rule?' he commented.[48] Nonetheless, for mid-level Indian diplomats who worked in Afghanistan, India's Afghanistan policy changed tremendously. According to one such official India 'not only focused horizontally across the country, but also vertically, in the rural areas'.[49] Such horizontal and vertical presence in Afghanistan, it can be argued, was possible only because India never sought a detailed accounting of funds that